



Sanchi gate

Four magnificent gateways lead to the Great Stupa at Sanchi. Dating from the first century BCE, these “torans” are decorated with intricate carvings that are one of the greatest artistic achievements of ancient Indian art. They show scenes from the life of Buddha and feature motifs such as Ashoka’s famous four lions.

500 The number of war elephants presented by Chandragupta to Seleucus I Nicator in 305 BCE, in return for giving up his claims to Indian lands. He used the elephants in battles fought between Alexander’s “successors,” notably in the defeat of Antigonus at Ipsus in 301 BCE.



that he successfully expanded Mauryan territories south into the Deccan, so that only the southern tip of India, plus the Kalinga area in the east (now in Orissa state), were not incorporated in the empire.

Bindusara’s son, Ashoka, the third emperor (c. 265–232 BCE) was the last major ruler of the Mauryan dynasty and one of the great figures of ancient history. It was Ashoka who brought the empire to its greatest extent, gaining the Kalinga region after a particularly bloody battle. It was said that the waters of the Daya River, next

to the battlefield, ran red with the blood of the many thousands fallen.

Ashoka is seen as presiding over a golden age. As his empire prospered, he promoted the arts and sciences

and instigated a vast building program. This included a great many stupas (mound-shaped shrines), built to house supposed relics of Buddha.

At some point in his reign, Ashoka converted to the fast-growing religion of

Buddhism. According to a story that mirrors the tale of his grandfather’s repentance, he converted in remorse at

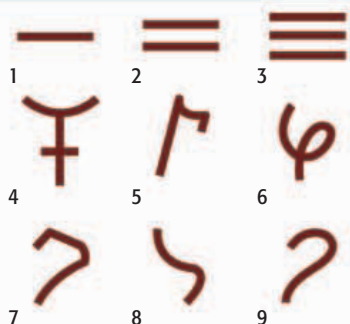
“All men are **my children**. What I desire for my own children... I desire for **all men**.”

ASHOKA IN ONE OF HIS ROCK EDICTS, c.240 BCE

INVENTION

DECIMAL NUMBER SYSTEMS

Indian mathematics advanced greatly under the Mauryans and Guptas (see AFTER). By the 4th century BCE, scholars were developing the idea of using combinations of units of different sizes. By the 1st century CE, they had devised a decimal-like system using the symbols shown here and refined the concept of zero as a “placeholder” to add and multiply numbers. The concept spread from India to the Islamic world and finally to the West, where it underlies the modern number system.



Great Stupa of Sanchi

Sanchi, central India, is home to one of the most impressive examples of Ashoka’s stupa-building program in the 3rd century BCE. It was added to over subsequent centuries.

the waste and bloodshed of the Kalinga War, turning his back on violence and embracing the peaceful Buddhist way of life. He sent missionaries to spread the word far and wide throughout Asia, including Sri Lanka, and in so doing played a major role in the development of Buddhism. He also spread the word through his edicts—sayings inscribed on stone pillars and rocks across India, Nepal, Pakistan, and Afghanistan. These set out his principles of peace, morality, respect, and humane rule, and of being the father who guides his people’s spiritual welfare.

End of an era

The peace and prosperity of Ashoka’s reign did not continue long after his death. Subsequent rulers lost territories and prestige, and there were squabbles over the succession. The last Mauryan emperor, Brihadratha, was assassinated c. 185 BCE by his chief aide, Pusyamitra, founder of the Sunga dynasty, which ruled central India until c. 73 BCE. India was now revisiting its chaotic, divided pre-Mauryan history. Small kingdoms arose in northern India, among them those of the so-called “Indo-Greek” rulers. The most famous of these was Menander (155–130 BCE), who may have battled with the Sungas.

The 1st–3rd centuries CE saw the Kushans from the steppes of Central Asia ruling in the north while small dynasties came and went elsewhere. As these crumbled, the way was paved for the great empire of the Guptas.



DETAIL FROM AJANTA CAVE PAINTINGS

THE GUPTA EMPIRE

Around 320 CE, the region of Magadha gave birth to another great dynasty and empire, the **Guptas**, who dominated northern India until c. 540 CE. The Gupta dynasty’s real empire-builders were its two first kings: **Chandra Gupta I** (c. 320–330) and his son, Samudra Gupta (c. 330–380). Great artistic achievements of this well-administrated, prosperous empire include the **Ajanta cave paintings** in western India. Some of these show episodes from the life of Buddha.

ART, RELIGION, AND SCIENCE

The Gupta era is often seen as the “classical” period of Indian culture, especially of **Hindu** and **Buddhist art**. The Guptas had a strong Hindu leaning, but Jainism and Buddhism also flourished. The classic image of **Buddha** developed, with a peaceful, reflective expression and curls flat against his head. Jain and Buddhist monks also created wonderful sculpted friezes at the **Udayagiri caves** (below). Wealthy patrons also encouraged architecture, dance, drama, and Sanskrit epics, while great advances were made in mathematics, astronomy, philosophy, logic, and medicine.



GUPTA-ERA BUDDHA

DEMISE OF THE GUPTAS

Under the fourth Gupta ruler, Kumara Gupta (c. 415–455), cracks began to appear in the empire as it faced incursions by **Hephthalite** nomads (or “White Huns”) from the north. By the 6th century, the Guptas had pulled back to their original heartland, and India was again a patchwork of small kingdoms **180 >>**



UDAYAGIRI CAVES